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Author(s): John McCracken

Source: *The Society of Malawi Journal*, Vol. 64, No. 1 (2011), pp. 1-12

Published by: [Society of Malawi - Historical and Scientific](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/41289168>

Accessed: 29/01/2014 07:29

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# BICYCLES IN COLONIAL MALAWI: A SHORT HISTORY

John McCracken

## *Introduction*

Much has been written about the history of transport in Africa but virtually nothing on the history of the bicycle. Neither A G Hopkins in his path breaking *Economic History of West Africa* nor Forbes Munro in his standard textbook even mention the bicycle, though both authors provide lengthy analyses of the impact of steamships, railways and lorries in expanding international trade and extending it into the interior of Africa.<sup>1</sup> Ralph Austen in his *African Economic History* mentions bicycle-repairing as one of the new 'informal sector' occupations attracting African artisans.<sup>2</sup> But neither he nor C C Wrigley in his important chapter in the *Cambridge History of Africa* make any attempt to evaluate the role of bicycles beyond Wrigley's comment that they were used to transport commodities as well as people.<sup>3</sup> General histories are equally unforthcoming. In a typically effective summary, John Iliffe describes the dual impact first of railways and then of motor transport on Africa's colonial economy but ignores bicycles entirely.<sup>4</sup> So too does Richard Reid in his history of the continent from 1800 to the present.<sup>5</sup> Only occasionally, as in Terence Ranger's recent social history of Bulawayo, is attention given to the cultural significance of bicycles in an urban setting.<sup>6</sup> Even rarer are studies like Anthony Nwabughuogu's article on the role of bicycle transport in eastern Nigeria which seek to evaluate the economic consequences on rural economies of the spread of the bicycle.<sup>7</sup> If little has

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<sup>1</sup> A G Hopkins, *An Economic History of West Africa* (Longman, London, 1973); J Forbes Munro, *Africa and the International Economy 1800-1960* (J M Dent & Sons, London, 1976).

<sup>2</sup> Ralph Austen, *African Economic History* (James Currey, London, 1987), p. 134.

<sup>3</sup> C C Wrigley, 'Aspects of Economic History' in A D Roberts (ed), *The Cambridge History of Africa Vol 7* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1986) p. 84.

<sup>4</sup> John Iliffe, *Africans The History of a Continent* (Cambridge University Press, Cambridge, 1995).

<sup>5</sup> Richard J Reid, *A History of Modern Africa: 1800 to the Present* (Wiley-Blackwell, Chichester, 2009)

<sup>6</sup> Terence Ranger, *Bulawayo Burning: A Social History of a Southern African City 1893-1960* (James Currey, Woodbridge, 2010). See also Terence Ranger, 'Bicycles and the Social History of Bulawayo' in Jane Morris (ed), *Short Writings from Bulawayo* (Amabooks, Bulawayo, 2003), pp. 76-81.

<sup>7</sup> Anthony I Nwabughuogu, 'The Role of Bicycle Transport in the Economic Development of Eastern Nigeria, 1930-45', *Journal of Transport History*, 5, 1984, pp. 91-98.

been written on the history of the bicycle in Africa generally, Malawi has fared even worse. As the indirect product of David Livingstone's obsession with finding a waterway for steamers into the east African interior, Nyasaland/Malawi has attracted a considerable amount of attention from transport historians. Much has been written on the opportunities and obstacles offered by the Shire-Zambezi waterway as a transport route during the early colonial period.<sup>8</sup> The impact of Nyasaland's railways has been given detailed attention both by Cynthia Crosby and in two influential studies by Leroy Vail.<sup>9</sup> There is an excellent account of the use made of the mission steamer, the *Chauncy Maples*, in extending the influence of the Universities Mission to Central Africa up and down the east coast of Lake Malawi.<sup>10</sup> Even the short-lived history of flying boats on Lake Malawi has been the subject of several articles.<sup>11</sup> Yet, out of 66 articles listed under 'transport and communications' in the index of the *Society of Malawi Journal*, there is only one paper, a two-page note by L J McDonald, which deals with bicycles at all.<sup>12</sup>

Even when reference is made to the purchase of bicycles by Malawian farmers or migrant workers historians have adopted a curiously negative tone. Leroy Vail in his impressively argued account of the vicissitudes of Malawi's colonial economy castigates farmers in the 1950s for purchasing 'unproductive' consumer goods such as clothing and bicycles rather than 'better tools, fertilizer, improved seed and the like.'<sup>13</sup> There is

<sup>8</sup> For a recent account see Elias Mandala, 'Feeding and Fleecing the Native: How the Nyasaland Transport System distorted a new Food Market, 1890s-1920s', *Journal of Southern African Studies*, 32, 3, 2006, pp.505-524.

<sup>9</sup> C A Crosby, 'Railway Development in Malawi: The early Years, 1895-1915' in Roderick J Macdonald (ed), *From Nyasaland to Malawi* (East African Publishing House, Nairobi, 1975), pp. 124-43; Leroy Vail, 'Railway Development and Colonial Underdevelopment: the Nyasaland Case' in R. Palmer and N. Parsons (eds), *The Roots of Rural Poverty in Central and Southern Africa* (London, 1977) and Vail, 'The Making of an Imperial Slum: Nyasaland and her Railways, 1895-1935', *Journal of African History*, 16 (1975), 89-112.

<sup>10</sup> Charles M Good Jr., *The Steamer Parish* (University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 2004).

<sup>11</sup> K B Willis, 'To England by Flying boat', *Society of Malawi Journal*, 33, 1 1980, pp. 33-38; Colin A Baker, 'Lake Malawi's First Flying Boat Visit', *SMJ*, 41, 2, 1988, pp. 30-32; Baker, 'Flying Boat Visit 1928: Nyasaland at the Aviation Cross Roads', *SMJ*, 44, 1 1991, pp. 9-33; Baker, 'Flying-Boat Service to Nyasaland 1949-1950', *SMJ* 48, 2, 1995, pp. 47-69.

<sup>12</sup> L J McDonald, 'Bicycles in B.C.A.', *Nyasaland Journal* 15, 2, 1962 pp. 33-34.

<sup>13</sup> Vail, 'The State and the Creation of Colonial Malawi's Agricultural Economy', in Robert I. Rotberg (ed), *Imperialism, Colonialism and Hunger: East and Central Africa* (Lexington Books, Lexington Mass, 1983) p. 69

more than a touch here of Robin Hallett's suggestion that the growth of migrant labour from Central Africa could be explained partly by 'the attraction of the white man's marvellous *toys* [my emphasis] – his bicycles and sewing machines.'<sup>14</sup> There is no indication of what will be argued here, that bicycles, then as now, constituted an exceptionally cost-effective, flexible means of transport, of great value in transporting a range of items throughout the rural hinterland, yet not requiring the expensive investment in roads and fuel needed by lorries and tractors. It may well be, as Wrigley has suggested, that some African purchasers of bicycles in the early years of the twentieth century were influenced in part by the desire to acquire a status symbol (commensurate perhaps with the Mercedes of the 1960s) which bestowed on the owner authority and recognition.<sup>15</sup> But the central reason why so many successful migrant workers in the 1930s and 40s put their savings into bicycles or sewing machines was that they recognised the economic value of what they were purchasing.

This paper seeks to provide a chronological account of the introduction and spread of bicycles in Malawi between 1895, when the first safety bicycle was imported into Nyasaland, and the eve of independence. In the early days, as so often in Africa, the new technology was largely the preserve of Europeans. But by the First World War several members of Nyasaland's growing African elite had acquired bicycles, primarily as a means of personal transport. In the late 1920s, however, fish traders, who had previously carried their wares on foot, began to acquire bicycles, and their example was followed by migrant workers returning from South Africa or Southern Rhodesia. By the late 1940s some better-off farmers were also purchasing bicycles, though in Nyasaland, unlike Bulawayo, these appear to have been owned and ridden almost entirely by men. Even in the 1950s bicycles remained scarce items owned by only a small proportion of the population. By this time, however, they had begun to be employed in the multiplicity of roles common in more recent times. Thus African policemen were equipped with bicycles in their bid to maintain law and order but so too, from 1959, were organising secretaries of the Nyasaland African Congress. Ministers of religion used bicycles to carry out visits to their parishioners. So too did fish traders, many of them former labour migrants. Bicycles were used to transport maize, rice, tobacco, cotton, charcoal and a range of other commodities. They also served as people-carriers, transporting wives and children to market. The expectation aroused by the introduction of other forms of transport in Malawi - notably steamships and railways - has all too

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<sup>14</sup> Robin Hallett, *Africa since 1875: A Modern History* (University of Michigan Press, Ann Arbor, 1974) p. 589.

<sup>15</sup> Wrigley, pp. 126-27.

often ended in disappointment. Bicycles, by contrast, like mobile phones today, are examples of forms of Western technology smoothly and easily introduced into Africa and having predominantly beneficial results. Indeed, it can be argued that while bicycles in the West have tended to be restricted to a relatively limited role - for recreation (their main function in America) or for personal transport over limited distances - bicycles in Malawi, as in other parts of Africa, have been used by their owners in a continually expanding variety of roles, many of them undreamed of by their makers.

### *Origins*

It is not surprising that the first, though abortive, attempt to introduce bicycles into Nyasaland was made by Frederick Moir. A mediocre businessman but an enthusiastic innovator, Moir had spent some time running a cycle agency in London in the 1870s before joining his brother John as joint manager of the African Lakes Company in 1877.<sup>16</sup> His interest in bicycles remained, however, and in 1883 he 'achieved undying fame . . . by importing and actually riding' a Penny Farthing, an ungainly monster with a 52-inch high front wheel and solid rubber tyres, at that time the most advanced form of bicycle available.<sup>17</sup>

It was in the mid-1890s, however, that the 'safety' bicycle – essentially the bicycle as we know it today – reached what was still British Central Africa. In the intervening period two key new improvements had been introduced, the diamond frame (featured on Rover Safety bicycles from 1885) and pneumatic tyres, first sold commercially in 1889.<sup>18</sup> Factories manufacturing bicycles had been established in Coventry, Birmingham and Nottingham, thus bringing their price down significantly. With Britain by the early 1890s caught up in a 'bicycle craze' involving King Edward VIII among others, settler Nyasaland could not be far behind. In 1893 Dr Henry, a Livingstonia missionary ordered a Quadrant safety bicycle only to die before it arrived.<sup>19</sup> In 1895, however, the colonial official R C F Maugham took possession of a safety bicycle, which he used on a number of short journeys in the Shire Highlands.<sup>20</sup> Harry Johnston, who first encountered bicycles at a fashionable house party in England in 1896, went out of his way to advise

<sup>16</sup> F.L. Moir, *After Livingstone*, (Hodder & Stoughton, London), p. 3

<sup>17</sup> Moir, *After Livingstone*, p. 186; R C F Maugham, *Africa as I have Known It* (London, 1929), p. 71.

<sup>18</sup> R. Watson and M. Gray, *The Penguin Book of the Bicycle* (Harmondsworth, Middlesex, 1978) pp. 119-21; David V Herlihy, *Bicycle: the History* (Yale University Press, New Haven, 2004), pp. 225-250

<sup>19</sup> Livingstonia Mission Committee Minutes, 31 August 1893, National Library of Scotland.

<sup>20</sup> Maugham, *Africa*, p. 71.

new settlers to bring a bicycle with them.<sup>21</sup> Both Scottish and Afrikaner missionaries followed his example.<sup>22</sup> By 1905 Blantyre could boast a cycle shop, selling the latest models of British made bicycles for between £6.00 and £2.10 (only a few years earlier the selling price had been £21).<sup>23</sup> Although the absence of good roads made cycling long distances difficult, one intrepid cyclist, H Testman, made the journey from Blantyre to Zomba (reckoned to take about 9-10 hours by machila) in 4 hours 10 minutes.<sup>24</sup> The solicitor, John Scott, cycled in a day from Blantyre to Chiromo and also from Blantyre to Fort Jameson, returning the following week.<sup>25</sup>

As in Britain, however, the enthusiasm for bicycles among Europeans was short-lived. One factor, as an article in *Life and Work in British Central Africa* made clear, was that the local conditions made cycling difficult for white men.<sup>26</sup>

The common cycle is not for the country. Our roads are too rough and too steep and the heat is too great for long distance riding on a bicycle. The exposure to the sun on a hot day is too risky for those who take prudent care of themselves.

What is more, by 1907, motor cycles were being introduced into Nyasaland in increasing numbers. Missionaries, with large parishes to be covered, were particularly enthusiastic customers. By 1913, there were five motor cycles at the Blantyre Mission and others owned at the Livingstonia Mission by Donald Fraser and by Drs Elmslie and Laws.<sup>27</sup> Several government officials now owned motor bicycles; bicycles proper had been largely abandoned by Europeans. Yet it is precisely at this time that African ownership of bicycles takes on new and more significant dimensions.

#### *Malawians and the Bicycle: The First Phase*

No one factor explains the initial Malawian love affair with bicycles.<sup>28</sup> Early migrants to Southern Rhodesia would certainly have seen

<sup>21</sup> Sir Harry Johnston, *The Story of My Life*, p. 310; H.H. Johnston, *British Central Africa*, p. 187.

<sup>22</sup> Alston Diaries, entry for 7 Jan 1896, Malawi National Archives.

<sup>23</sup> *Central African Times*, 18 Feb 1905. A few shop-soiled cycles were advertised for as low as £1.00.

<sup>24</sup> *CAT*, Jan 1902.

<sup>25</sup> *CAT*, 15 July 1905; 30 June 1906.

<sup>26</sup> *Life and Work in British Central Africa*, June-July 1900.

<sup>27</sup> Hetherwick to Elmslie, 1 Nov 1912; 3 Jan 1913; Elmslie to Hetherwick, 26 March 1913, Church of Scotland Papers, MNA.

<sup>28</sup> The Chichewa word for bicycle, 'njinga', had its origin as the word for bobbin or spool. It was in common use in the King's African Rifles by the 1940s. My thanks to George Shepperson for providing me with this information.

bicycles in Salisbury and Bulawayo, though prior to the First World War these were largely in European hands. Fred Moir's exploits on top of his Penny Farthing are said to have made a considerable impression on Malawians near Blantyre.<sup>29</sup> But it was through Christian missions and churches that the first direct contact with bicycles appears to have been made. As early as 1897, the Blantyre mission evangelists, James Gray Kamlinje and Mungo Murray Chisuse, on their visit to Scotland were taught how to bicycle, though whether they made use of this skill when they returned to Nyasaland is not known.<sup>30</sup> David Clement Scott, the head of the mission, believed that 'missionary distances will call almost for a bicycle corps' and in consequence was supportive of Malawian employees at the mission learning to ride and, if possible, acquire bicycles.<sup>31</sup> The New Year Sports held at Mandala in 1905 concluded with an 'exhibition of trick cycles . . . by one of the natives employed at the Blantyre mission.'<sup>32</sup> Following an accident in Victoria Avenue in 1906 involving Sergeant Spedi of the Blantyre police force, the settler newspaper, the *Central African Times*, demanded that 'some control [should be] exercised over budding native cyclists.' In its view: 'the principal streets of Blantyre are not intended as the playground of native cyclists.'<sup>33</sup>

These complaints, however, did not prevent several members of Southern Nyasaland's small Christian, land-owning community acquiring bicycles before the First World War. They included the pioneer Blantyre minister, Harry Kambwiri, an accomplished cyclist who in 1913 borrowed John Chilembwe's bicycle on two occasions.<sup>34</sup> Chilembwe, for all the financial pressures he lived under, owned a bicycle outright as did several others of his closest associates including Duncan Njilima, John Gray Kufa and Gordon Mataka, fellow landowners at Nsoni, and George Masangano, a former Blantyre Christian who then joined the Church of Christ Mission before establishing his own independent church.<sup>35</sup> For all these men, bicycles were undoubtedly useful means of transport. But it is more than likely that, for members of this elite group, bicycles were also prestige objects

<sup>29</sup> Maughan, *Africa*, p. 71.

<sup>30</sup> *LWBCA*, Dec 1897. For more on this visit see John McCracken, 'Mungo Murray Chisuse

<sup>31</sup> *LWBCA* Aug-Feb 1897.

<sup>32</sup> *CAT* Jan 1905.

<sup>33</sup> *CAT* 24 Nov 1906

<sup>34</sup> Evidence of Rev Harry Kambwiri to the Nyasaland Rising Commission of Inquiry, MNA Com-6 2/1/3.

<sup>35</sup> Case of John Gray Kufa Mapantha, 3 Feb 1915, MNA S 10/1/3; Case of prisoner Gordon Malindima Mattaka, 2 March 1915, MNA S 10/1/3; Statement by George Masangano at the camp, Zomba, 26 Jan 1915, MNA S 10/1/2; George Shepperson and Thomas Price, *Independent African* (Edinburgh University Press, 1959), p. 246.

demonstrating, as did the hats and formal Western-style suits they wore, their right to be considered as civilised gentlemen in an overwhelmingly racist society. During the reprisals following the Chilembwe rising, in which all but Kambwiri and Mataka had been involved, almost all of their bicycles were looted by the government forces.

### *The Interwar Years*

The interwar years witnessed new developments in transport in Nyasaland. In the early stages it was the rise of the motor car that dominated. Cars had existed in Nyasaland from 1907 but the inadequacy of roads and the shortage of petrol and spare parts placed major obstacles to their use. Head portage continued to provide virtually the only method of transporting goods except in that part of the country served by the railway from Chindio to Blantyre. During the course of the war, however, thousands of labourers were employed in the construction of motor roads, notably the road linking Blantyre to Fort Johnston, and hundreds of lorries and cars were introduced as means of speeding up the movement of supplies.<sup>36</sup>

The coming of peace gave a new impetus to the shift in patterns of communications. In 1919 nearly every planter and firm in the neighbourhood of Blantyre was said to have acquired a car, though at that time they could still be most usefully employed in the Shire Highlands.<sup>37</sup> In the late-1920s, however, a dirt road from Blantyre to Lilongwe was opened which could be used by motor transport, at least in the dry season. By 1929 over 450 lorries and 600 cars were licensed in the Protectorate, all but three of them at this stage owned by Europeans or Asians.<sup>38</sup> European use of bicycles had almost come to an end with the exception of the occasional missionary (Fergus Macpherson at Livingstonia in the mid-1950s was one) who continued to use bicycles for reasons of economy and because motor transport was not available to their African colleagues.<sup>39</sup> Colonial officials touring their districts on *ulendo* usually walked or were carried in a hammock. However, in the Karonga District in the late 1940s, Henry Phillips took a bicycle with him along with a messenger employed to carry the cycle up hills.<sup>40</sup>

The rise of the motor car was accompanied by a far larger increase in the number of bicycles. Up into the late 1920s bicycles in Nyasaland remained largely the preserve of a salaried elite including ministers of

<sup>36</sup> Philip Mitchell, *African Afterthoughts* (London, 1954), 38-9; Nyasaland Military Handbook, 1922, MNA S2/6/27.

<sup>37</sup> LWBCA July 1918-June 1919, 23-4.

<sup>38</sup> Nyasaland Military Handbook, 31 Dec 1929, MNA S2/6/27.

<sup>39</sup> Fergus Macpherson, *North of the Zambezi* (Handsell Press, Edinburgh, 1998), pp. 42, 67, 145, 178-9.

<sup>40</sup> Henry Phillips, *From Obscurity to Bright Dawn* (Radcliffe Press, 1998), p. 18.

religion, civil servants, head teachers and non-commissioned officers in the Kings African Rifles, one of whom is recorded in 1932 as having used his £9 gratuity in order to purchase a bicycle.<sup>41</sup> Their numbers expanded from the early 1930s despite the introduction of an onerous licensing system, partly as a result of the decision of the colonial government to supply district clerks and court messengers with bicycles but more as a consequence of the expansion of commercial fishing.<sup>42</sup>

Fish trading in Malawi has a long history going back at least to the mid-nineteenth century when dried fish from the south end of Lake Malawi was regularly exchanged for maize and beans from the more productive highland districts. It was the opening of the market to Blantyre and Zomba from the end of the First World War, however, which brought about the major change.<sup>43</sup> At first, traders carried dried fish on long poles slung over their shoulders but by 1931, according to the census of that year, traders had begun to use bicycles to transport fresh fish from Lake Chilwa to Blantyre and Zomba as well as dried fish from Lake Malawi which was traded all over the southern province.<sup>44</sup> By 1933 more than 3,000 people were said to be involved in the fish trade from Fort Johnston (Mangoche), most of them cyclists, carrying their wares in large baskets strapped to the backs of their carriers.<sup>45</sup> Cycle repair shops sprang up at every district centre. An enterprising entrepreneur in Zomba began renting bicycles to traders, charging 6d. per round trip to Lake Malawi plus one fish out of every 200 carried. Most fish sold in Zomba were now coming from Lake Malombe, retailed by Malawians on bicycles. 'Of all African industries, the fish trade is the one that has made most progress in recent years,' the Provincial Commissioner reported in 1939, adding that 'the fish carrier's bicycle is familiar to both sight and smell on every road.'<sup>46</sup>

By this time, bicycle traders from Lake Malawi were facing competition from Greek and Asian entrepreneurs using lorries. But they had the advantage over their competitors in that they could carry fish to a network of rural markets which could not be reached by motor transport. When the rains came, that advantage grew. In the mid 1950s traders using bicycles were able to make their way to the Cholo and Mlanje tea estates during the rainy

<sup>41</sup> Timothy Lovering, *Authority and Identity: Malawian Soldiers in Britain's Colonial Army*, Stirling University PhD, 2002, p.284.

<sup>42</sup> Lilongwe District Report for 1933, MNA S1/112 A-E/34.

<sup>43</sup> For an introduction see John McCracken, 'Fishing and the Colonial Economy: the Case of Malawi', *Journal of African History*, 28 (1987), pp. 413-29.

<sup>44</sup> Nyasaland Protectorate Report of the Census for 1931, MNA S1/109/30

<sup>45</sup> Southern Province Annual Report for 1933, MNA NS 3/1/4.

<sup>46</sup> Southern Province Annual Report for 1939, MNA NS 3/1/8.

season over roads that had become impassable to lorries.<sup>47</sup> Even the most successful European fishing company, Yiannakis Brothers, found it expedient to sell about a third of its catch to 'bicycle boys' at various lorry stops on the way to the firm's Blantyre depot rather than to compete directly with them.<sup>48</sup>

With the growth of the fish trade, imports of bicycles expanded. Between 1935 and 1939 the number of bicycles annually imported through Chikwawa increased from 93 to 3,970.<sup>49</sup> Some of these in the early 1930s were cheap imports from Japan sold at the bargain price of £3.00 new. However, most of these Japanese bicycles disintegrated under the exceptional loads placed upon them leaving the market dominated by more durable British 'roadsters', Raleigh, Humber and Hercules.<sup>50</sup> In 1936 of 3,237 bicycles imported to the Southern Province, 95.7% were British made.<sup>51</sup> An expensive commodity, sold in the early 1930s at around five pounds fifteen shillings, bicycles were well beyond the reach of most Malawians, whose average monthly wage on estates at that time was only eight to nine shillings. But with the easing of the depression and the expansion of tobacco growing on the Lilongwe Plain, better-off tobacco farmers began to purchase bicycles: 4,269 bicycle licenses were issued in the Lilongwe District in 1940.<sup>52</sup> So too did labour migrants returning from Southern Rhodesia and South Africa. In a survey conducted in the Southern Province in 1949 on the reasons for migration, 35.33% of people questioned replied 'to obtain money necessary to buy bicycles'.<sup>53</sup> Not all migrants were successful in doing so. But for the better paid, the bicycle was now a realistic purchase. In 1949 workers recruited by the Witwatersrand Native Labour Association to South Africa's gold mines were paid 70-100 shillings a month, much of it deferred until the end of their contract. Although clothes were the largest single category of commodities purchased, bicycles, used in retail trade or to transport crops to market, were frequently bought, even by migrants from marginal areas.<sup>54</sup> By

<sup>47</sup> Wiseman Chijere Chirwa, 'Theba is Power: Rural Labour, Migrancy and Fishing in Malawi, 1890s-1985', PhD, Queen's University Kingston, Ontario, 1992, p.461.

<sup>48</sup> Evidence of A.D. Sanson, Fisheries Officer, to the Commission of Inquiry into the Fishing Industry, 8 June 1959, MNA COM 9/4/2.

<sup>49</sup> Southern Province Annual Report for 1939, MNA NS 3/1/8.

<sup>50</sup> Evidence of the Governor, Senior Provincial Commissioner and Director of Agriculture to the Hilton Young Commission, 18 June 1938, Foreign Office Library.

<sup>51</sup> Annual Report for Southern Province for 1936, MNA NS 3/1/6.

<sup>52</sup> Annual Report for Lilongwe District for 1940, MNA NCL 4/1/5.

<sup>53</sup> Report of a Labour Survey undertaken in the Southern Province of Nyasaland concerning emigration of Nyasaland natives in search of work, 1949, MNA MB 3/3/3 quoted in Wiseman Chirwa, 'Theba is Power', p. 408.

<sup>54</sup> Joseph H C Mfuni, 'Labour Migration from Northern Mzimba', Chancellor College, History Seminar Paper, 1982.

this time, many of these were not directly involved in the fishing industry. According to the Labour Department, out of the 40,000 bicycles licensed in Nyasaland in 1941 only about a quarter were used in fish-trading.<sup>55</sup>

*African Bicyclists in the 1950s*

Following the outbreak of the Second World War, trade with Britain was temporarily disrupted, resulting in an acute shortage of new bicycles, tubes and tyres. The number of fish traders fell. Fishermen were no longer able to unpick old tyres to make their nets, a practice that had developed in the 1930s.<sup>56</sup> But with peace restored, the value of bicycle imports increased once more, from £26,000 in 1945 to £310,000 in 1953.<sup>57</sup> In the Blantyre district 7,838 bicycle licences were issued in 1948 as compared with 5,464 in 1947.<sup>58</sup>

Some indication of the marked regional variety in the use of bicycles can be obtained from F.C. Wright's pamphlet, *African Consumers in Nyasaland and Tanganyika*, published in 1955. Few bicycles were registered in the Nkhata Bay and Rumphi districts where steep hills made cycling a particularly arduous activity. But in the Mulanje district 16,900 bicycles were registered in 1952 and a similar number was noted in the Zomba district where, so it was claimed, one in four able-bodied adult males now owned a bicycle.<sup>59</sup> Unlike in Bulawayo, where young women cyclists became a common sight in the post-war years, there were few women cyclists in Nyasaland.<sup>60</sup> However, in Fort Johnston (Mangoche) in 1952 'African women were seen riding bicycles; some of them had acquired women's bicycles.'<sup>61</sup>

Government deployment of bicycles was extended by the 1950s from court messengers to African policemen. Bicycles, for a while, were also seen as valuable tools for the growing nationalist movement. In the annals of nationalism, a key event was Kwame Nkrumah's donation to the Malawi Congress Party of a fleet of Land Rovers in 1961. But it may well be that Congress's purchase, two years earlier, of 33 bicycles was of equal importance. Presented by Dunduzu Chisiza to Congress district organisers in a ceremony recorded on film, the bicycles significantly improved Congress's

<sup>55</sup> Annual Report of the Labour Department for 1941 quoted in Chirwa, "Theba is Power" p. 407.

<sup>56</sup> South Nyasa District Annual Reports for 1943 and 1944, MNA NSF 4/1/6.

<sup>57</sup> A.G. Irvine, *The Balance of Payments of Rhodesia and Nyasaland* (London, 1959), p. 170

<sup>58</sup> Blantyre District Annual Report for 1948, MNA NS/3/14.

<sup>59</sup> F.C. Wright, *African Consumers in Nyasaland and Tanganyika* (London, HMSO, 1955), Appendix B.

<sup>60</sup> For women cyclists in Bulawayo see Ranger, 'Bicycles'

<sup>61</sup> Ibid.

ability to coordinate its strategy.<sup>62</sup> In the early weeks of 1959, Chakalipe Phiri spent much of his time cycling through the Northern Province holding meetings wherever he dismounted. Following the declaration of a state of emergency, he continued to use his bicycle to organise meetings, stopping only when he was arrested.<sup>63</sup>

### Conclusion

In his discussion of bicycles in the social history of Bulawayo, Terence Ranger describes how 'young dandies' in the 1940s went out of their way to decorate and polish their bicycles: 'We were competing in smartness not beer. When we cycle to our rural homes, people would know that there is so-and-so who is very smart.'<sup>64</sup> In the environs of Blantyre, where 12 bicycle repairers existed in 1931, 'young dandies' also no doubt combined a keen recognition of the bicycle as a valuable means of transport with their pride in a prestige object.<sup>65</sup> Most workers from outlying villages continued to walk into town, so the anthropologists Bettison and Rigby noted in 1957, but a proud minority now regularly cycled instead.<sup>66</sup>

For many Malawians, however, ownership of a bicycle was the key to survival in a remarkably tough and poverty-stricken environment. Take the case of the fish-trader Namango Nachuma who gave evidence to the Commission of Inquiry into the Fishing Industry in 1956. To ply his trade, Nachuma, from Chaoni village in the Cholo District, had to cycle for three days to the eastern shore of Lake Chilwa, evading the Portuguese police who had arrested several of his friends. At the lake he could wait for five days or more to fill his basket of 240 fish, before spending a further four days making the laborious return journey to the market at Mikolongwe. He bought the fish for 3d each and sold them for 4d or 5d in the market, a paper profit of from £1 to £2 for a gruelling twelve day expedition, but one that does not take account of the cost of tyres, which had to be replaced at least three times a year, or of his bicycle which lasted less than three years and cost £3.15s when new.<sup>67</sup> Given that the most energetic trader was unlikely to be able to make more than two trips a month, Nachuma's maximum profit cannot have exceeded £39 a year. But this was better than the 30 shillings a month with rations paid

<sup>62</sup> Nyasaland Intelligence Report for January 1959, MNA PRO CO 1015/1749.

<sup>63</sup> K. Chakalipe Phiri, 'Autobiography', MNA Acc.167/KCP/1/1.

<sup>64</sup> Ranger, 'Bicycles'.

<sup>65</sup> Blantyre District Annual Report for 1931, MNA NSB 7/1/2.

<sup>66</sup> D G Bettison and P J A Rigby, *Pattern of Income and Expenditure – Blantyre-Limbe, Nyasaland*, Rhodes-Livingstone Communication No. 20, Lusaka 1961.

<sup>67</sup> Evidence of Namango Nacuma to Commission of Inquiry into the Fishing Industry, Blantyre 17-19 July 1956, MNA COM 9/3/1.

as minimum wages on Cholo estates, particularly as it allowed him an independence which wage labour denied.

Namango Nachuma's evidence points to the hard struggle for survival experienced by many Malawians. But it does not detract from the basic lesson that the bicycle has been good for Malawi and Malawians have been good for the bicycle. All too often western technology has been introduced to Africa in inappropriate forms. But in the case of the bicycle, the heavy-duty roadster, for some 60 years 'the corner-stone of African cycling', was admirably suited for its task.<sup>68</sup> Over the decades, the bicycle has gone through many different and often highly expensive forms in the West as manufacturers have attempted to attract new customers. But there is growing recognition that the only significant improvement over the first basic design as represented in the roadster has come in the introduction of gears.<sup>69</sup> Whereas the cost of cars and lorries put them well beyond the reach of all but a few exceptional Malawians prior to the late 1950s, bicycles, as we have seen, were in Malawian hands from the 1890s and were being widely purchased from the mid-1930s onwards.

The other side has been the ingenuity demonstrated by Malawians in adapting the bicycle to their needs. The use of large straw panniers to carry dried fish was an early innovation which has been followed by many more. In the Southern Province, for example, where oxen and hence ox-drawn carts were almost entirely non-existent, well-off peasant farmers used bicycles to transport their crops to market. Bicycle taxis in Lilongwe are a more recent innovation. The use made of bicycles to transport firewood down from Zomba Plateau is another. Bicycles, though not made in Malawi, can be easily and efficiently repaired there. Fuel is never a problem. The desperately high accident rate on Malawi's roads is predominantly, though not entirely, a result of the growth of motor transport. Bicycles cannot solve the basic need for an efficient, reliable transport system linking Malawi to the East African coast. But as a means of moving people and produce cheaply within the country they have proved themselves to be invaluable.

**Editors' Note:** The Malawians' love affair with the bicycle is affectionately reflected in the title of Sir Denys Roberts' biting, satirical novel *The Bones of the Wajingas*, London, Methuen & Co. 1959, in which colonial Nyasaland is very thinly disguised as Wajingaland. Sir Denys served as Crown Counsel in Nyasaland 1953-1960. During a highly distinguished and successful career he was later (1979) to be appointed Chief Justice of the Supreme Court in Hong Kong. He retired from judicial service in 2003.

<sup>68</sup> Watson and Gray, *Penguin Book of Bicycle*, p. 178.

<sup>69</sup> Watson and Gray; David V Herlihy, *Bicycle*.